

Preaching as *Locus Theologicus*: The Power of Practicing Theology in the Twenty-First Century

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ABSTRACT: While only a small portion of the presbyterate will assume the specific mission of theology—as researching and teaching—almost every priest will exercise the ministry of preaching. The homily is the place where theology must become a living reality, in the sense of developing new theological insights as theologian-pastors guide their flocks; and in the fresh application of theological learning to the challenges of our times. Throughout history, some of the best contributions to theology were delivered orally, as seen in the examples of Augustine and Benedict XVI. The rediscovery of preaching as an important place for theology will bring the benefits of better homilies, effective on-going formation for the clergy, and renewed theological production.

KEY WORDS: Preaching, oral theology, priestly formation, Augustine, Benedict XVI

INTRODUCTION

Recently, at a homiletics class, I asked my students—deacons, or soon to be ordained deacons—if they were looking forward to their lives as theologians. Sensing their confusion, I asked directly if they would see themselves as theologians once their studies were completed. Not one of them said yes. They all agreed, quite honestly, that theology felt more like a requirement for ordination than as a discipline to be exercised throughout their priestly life.

At the root of this outlook we find a restrictive understanding of theology as the formal academic endeavor of researching, writing and teaching. While this is an important part of theology, to limit the exercise of theology to writing articles or teaching at universities would be as partial as thinking that a lawyer who does not publish in academic journals is not a lawyer.

A lawyer will apply what was learned to innumerable new situations in which, based on a constant deepening of the law, fresh answers will address real life problems. When theology is confined to libraries and classrooms—as it is often the case—some problems arise. First, theology itself can become the profession of an elite, sometimes more interested in certain standards born of politics and academic echo chambers than in the urgent and real answers needed in our times. Second, what was learned in long years of study becomes a distant memory, and the minds of priests are not always rooted in the effort of deepening themselves in God's truth, but in a myriad of urgent situations.

In this way, theology and daily priestly life are experienced as distant realities. A problem and an opportunity come from this situation. The problem: homilies are often a poor and scattered collection of thoughts, that in unnecessarily long speeches, offer little light to illumine the wonders of God's revelation and the answers for our problems. The opportunity: the homily can become the key to recover the living and necessary place of theology in the life of a priest. While only a small portion of a presbyterate will publish books, every single priest will preach. Rather than seeing the preparation for the homily as another of the many tasks to be fulfilled during the week, this ministry can become the regular space for exercising theology. In this way, theology will not be restricted to a career for the few, and preaching can be renewed by the honest and constant quest for the truth and beauty of God.

1. PREACHING AS *LOCUS THEOLOGICUS*

This means that—freely borrowing a category from classic theology—preaching can be understood as *locus theologicus*.¹ Melchior Cano (1509–1560) famously defined this concept as “domicilia omnium argumentorum theologicorum.”² The *loci* are the places where authority is found, and thus, where we can encounter the grammar for articulating the faith (e.g., Scripture, Tradition, Councils, Fathers, etc.).

It is important to see these places not only in a passive way, but also as the active and living spaces where argumentation occurs. It is in this way that we can say that preaching can be fruitfully understood as *locus theologicus*: a place, a domicile, a home for the real exercise of theology today. It is in deepening the value and importance of preaching that theology can be renewed as a living and essential part of the daily life of priests. For this, let me mention three areas of preaching as a home for theology.

A Place for Encountering the Word

A first space in this domicile is the importance of listening to the Word. The many urgencies of priestly life and the incessant distractions of our postmodern society can become obstacles for the first duty of any preacher: to listen actively to the Word of God in prayer. Cardinal Sarah expresses this with clarity and depth: “The priestly dignity requires us to realize the importance of our own words. Everything in the priest, body and soul, must pro-

1 See about this: Ambroise Gardeil, “Lieux théologiques,” in *Dictionnaire de Théologie Catholique*, vol. IX (Paris: Librairie Letouzey et Ané, 1926) 712–747; about Cano’s contribution and shortcomings, Yves M.-J. Congar, “Théologie,” in *Dictionnaire de Théologie Catholique*, vol. XV (Paris: Librairie Letouzey et Ané, 1946) 341–502, at 422. See also Louis Bouyer, *Dictionary of Theology* (New York: Desclee, 1965) 439–440.

2 Melchior Cano, *De locis theologicis*, ed. Juan Belda Plans, Biblioteca de Autores Cristianos. Maior 85 (Madrid: Ed. Católica, 2006) I,3 (p. 4). The work was published posthumously in Salamanca in 1563.

claim the Glory of God. . . . Above all, in order to nourish this speech, it is terribly important to remain silent.”³

The positive disposition to preach will move a priest to, first and foremost, listen. Certainly, there are different ways of listening. St. Augustine would tell his people: “You, then, listen with care and attention, while we bishops should listen with fear and apprehension.”⁴ A preacher does not only listen attentively, but also with the reverent fear of knowing that he will have to speak the truth. Mindful of his responsibility as a preacher, a priest must avoid distractions and remain silent in order to listen in prayer to what God says to him, and through him, to his people.

A Place to Encounter the Event of God’s Word

Moving on to another area of preaching as *locus*, we come to a place to contemplate the Liturgy of the Word in all its depth. It certainly makes a difference when a preacher sees the proclamation of God’s Word and his preaching as a mysterious and effective action and not just as a casual moment of human sharing.

Jean Corbon wrote about the specific character of reading the Word in the context of the liturgy: “In the Holy Spirit the words of Jesus are more than a form of teaching; they become an event.”⁵ There is a unique power when the words of Scripture resound in the liturgy: they are not only prayerfully remembered; they are proclaimed today by God through the Church, especially in the Gospel, which is proclaimed only by ordained ministers. Truly, the Word becomes an event.

The mission of preaching is a necessary occasion to constantly remind us of this powerfully reality. When a preacher is aware of

3 Robert Cardinal Sarah, *The Power of Silence: Against the Dictatorship of Noise*, trans. Michael J. Miller (San Francisco: Ignatius Press, 2017) 194.

4 Augustine, *Sermon* 46,1, trans. Edmund Hill, *Sermons (20-50) on the Old Testament*, The Works of Saint Augustine: A Translation for the 21st Century, III/2 (Brooklyn, NY: New City Press, 1990) 263.

5 Jean Corbon, *The Wellspring of Worship*, trans. Matthew J. O’Connell (San Francisco: Ignatius Press, 2005) 149.

the mystery at work when the Word is proclaimed, then he will be more aware of what happens when the bread of God's Word is broken for the people in the homily. He will remember the saying of Augustine to his people: "We here are your books."⁶ What our people learn about God, what they know and, explore usually does not come from actual reading, but from listening to preachers. This takes us to our next area.

A Place to Listen to Theology

There is something irreplaceable about orality. We read God's Word, we read articles, books and blogs. But "faith comes from what is heard" (Rom 10:17 RSV). A few years ago, at a conference on the Letter to the Galatians held at St. Andrews, Scotland, N. T. Wright had a simple and powerful idea: at the opening of the conference, all the participants were gathered in one room and one person read the entire Letter to the Galatians. It was an eloquent reminder of what we were actually reflecting on: not a theoretical text, not a text to be dissected in self-standing verses, but a letter to be heard by a community, in which the author, illumined by the Holy Spirit, applied the Gospel to a concrete problem. Is this not real theology?

All the decisive developments in Pauline theology come from letters that were heard by communities. Around two-thirds of patristic literature was originally spoken, and even what was written was dictated and frequently read aloud to groups of people. For the most part, the indispensable progress made in early Christian theology was made orally. As someone said, to read an early Christian text is to eavesdrop on a conversation.⁷

Here we come to a very important realization. The reason for the oral-auditory character of biblical and patristic literature is not

6 Augustine, *Sermon 227*, trans. Edmund Hill, in *Sermons (184-229Z) on the Liturgical Seasons*, The Works of Saint Augustine: A Translation for the 21st Century, III/6 (Brooklyn, NY: New City Press, 1993) 254.

7 Carol Harrison, *The Art of Listening in the Early Church* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2013) 2.

only sociological, i.e., the limited means for communication or the very restricted literacy of those times. Something more is at stake here.

Theology is, essentially, a dialogical activity, an encounter between people and communities with questions and longings, a common exploration of God's mysteries; a true and necessary conversation. Thus, orality has an important place in theology. It reminds us not only of the foundational efforts of early Christians to understand and share their faith, it takes us to what they heard, and what we must hear again today: the Word that was in the beginning and became flesh (see Jn 1:1.14). Christ, the eternal Logos, became one of us and assumed our human voice in order to tell us everything he had heard from his Father (see Jn 15:15). The Lord Jesus, in his infinite wisdom, chose to speak and not to write. The Word wanted us to keep his words and dwell in them, fulfilling in this way the prophecy of Isaiah:

For as the rain and the snow come down from heaven, and do not return there until they have watered the earth, making it bring forth and sprout, giving seed to the sower and bread to the eater, so shall my word be that goes out from my mouth; it shall not return to me empty, but it shall accomplish that which I purpose, and succeed in the thing for which I sent it. (Is 55:10–11)

The Word comes from on high to transform our hearts and thus, in the case of preachers, to be able to speak good things to God's people. If faith, as Joseph Ratzinger said, is "to re-think what has been heard,"⁸ then theology is the experience of reflecting on the Word and letting it (Him!) become words for others; it has to be a dialogue or it becomes vain human wisdom. And there is nothing like an oral setting if a real conversation is to happen. Preaching, therefore, is the privileged home for the exercise of theology: in it the Word still resounds and informs words that are pronounced and heard, thus leading the hearers to know and love God. It is true

⁸ Joseph Ratzinger, *Storia e Dogma*, trans. Riccardo Mazzarol (Milan: Jaca Book, 1993) 43, my translation.

homilein: to speak, and be in company with the other, to commune and be in harmony with the listeners. Augustine described this deep communion as he explained to his friend Deogratias how to catechize: “For this feeling of compassion is so strong that, when our listeners are touched by us as we speak and we are touched by them as they learn, each of us comes to dwell in the other.”⁹

In doing this, the Church is more than the human setting for this conversation. The Church is, as Ratzinger emphasized, the true subject of preaching.¹⁰ It is in the living communion of the Church that preaching, as an ecclesial activity, is a true place, an indispensable domicile for living theology.

2. THE CHALLENGE OF MAKING ORAL THEOLOGY TODAY

Two concrete examples of preaching—one ancient, one contemporary—can help us to find out some important keys for the task of making oral theology in our postmodern world.

The Christmas homilies of St. Augustine (*Sermons* 184–196) are an excellent model for concise, powerful, deeply theological, and eminently pastoral preaching.

These sermons are very short: not more than two pages in modern printed editions. And perhaps precisely because of that they can express so powerfully the mystery of the nativity, particularly the great paradox of the Incarnation: Jesus is the “speechless infant and Word.”¹¹ Indeed, “He lies in a manger but he holds the whole world in his hands; he sucks his mother’s breast, but feeds the angels; he is swaddled in rags, but clothes us in immortality; he is suckled, but also worshipped.”¹² He became man “that He,

9 Augustine, *Instructing Beginners in Faith*, trans. Raymond Canning, The Augustine Series V (Hyde Park, NY: New City Press, 2006) 12,17 (p. 97).

10 See Joseph Ratzinger, *Dogma and Preaching: Applying Christian Doctrine to Daily Life*, trans. Michael J. Miller et al. (San Francisco: Ignatius Press, 2011) 21–25.

11 Augustine, *Sermon* 184,3; trans. Hill, 19; see also *Sermon* 185,1, 187,1, 190,3; trans. Hill 21, 27, 39.

12 Augustine, *Sermon* 190,4; trans. Hill, 40.

the Bread, might be hungry; that He, the Fountain, might thirst.”¹³ Because of this, the Child Jesus, God and man, is “lovable and terrible, severe and serene,”¹⁴ and “since we are not yet ready for the banquet of our Father, let us grow familiar with the manger of our Lord Jesus Christ.”¹⁵

Similar paradoxes are seen also in Mary: “She fed our bread” and was “ruling our ruler”¹⁶ because of the power of Christ himself, who “created his mother.”¹⁷

Such profound insights of oral theology are not only deep but also effective, as the stark contrast of the paradoxes are a powerful way of inviting his audience to reflect on the mystery.

Augustine also knows how to bring these theological reflections into a very personal conversation with his people. In a natural way he often illumines people in different states of life with different aspects of the mystery,¹⁸ and relates the two nativities of Christ—eternal from the Father and in time from Mary—to the dignity of both sexes. He speaks to each person in front of him: “Consider, O man, what God became for your sake; understand this lesson of surpassing humility presented by a teacher who, as yet, says no word,”¹⁹ and, famously, “wake up, o man, it was for you that God was made man!”²⁰

Finally, the bishop of Hippo constantly invites his congregation to rejoice: to “let astonishment give way to thanksgiving and praise”²¹ by a “joyous gathering and appropriate festivity.”²² Is there any other possible disposition for someone who has been led by good preaching to the true celebration of such a great

13 Augustine, *Sermon* 191,1; trans. Hill, 42, modified.

14 Augustine, *Sermon* 195,3; trans. Hill, 58.

15 Augustine, *Sermon* 194,4; trans. Hill, 55, modified.

16 Augustine, *Sermon* 184,3; trans. Hill, 19, modified.

17 Augustine, *Sermon* 195,2; trans. Hill, 57; see also *Sermon* 186,1; trans. Hill, 24.

18 See Augustine, *Sermon* 184,2, 188,3, 192,2, 196,2; trans. Hill, 18, 32, 47, 61.

19 Augustine, *Sermon* 188,3; trans. Hill, 32, modified.

20 Augustine, *Sermon* 185,1; trans. Hill, 21, modified.

21 Augustine, *Sermon* 189,4; trans. Hill, 36.

22 Augustine, *Sermon* 184,2; trans. Hill, 18, modified.

grace as the birthday of Christ? “Look for merit there, look for a cause, look for justice; and see whether you can find anything but grace.”²³

The second example of profound and appealing oral theology in preaching is Pope Benedict XVI. The seven Easter homilies of his pontificate are jewels of prayer and Christian reflection in a mystery that, as he indicated, unlike that of the birth of Christ, is something very foreign to our human experience.²⁴ Because of this difficulty, Benedict frequently follows a mystagogical approach: with depth and beauty he explains the symbols of baptism (water and light),²⁵ those of the Easter Vigil liturgy (light, water, and the alleluia),²⁶ and again the mystery of light in the context of the new creation.²⁷

The homilies of Benedict XVI are an excellent example of the pastoral application of theological knowledge, as when he shares the information transmitted by Gregory of Tours²⁸ about the ancient practice of lighting the fire for the Easter Vigil directly from the sun, using a crystal: “Light and fire, so to speak, were received anew from heaven, so that all the lights and fires of the year could be kindled from them;”²⁹ or when he utilizes the apocryphal *Life of Adam and Eve*³⁰ (probably first century AD) to reflect on the search for a medicine for death and the need for a different cure: “The true cure for death must be different. It cannot lead

23 Augustine, *Sermon* 185,3; trans. Hill, 22.

24 Benedict XVI, *Homily at the Easter Vigil* (15 April 2006). The homilies of Benedict XVI are available at <https://w2.vatican.va/content/benedict-xvi/en/homilies/index.html#homilies>.

25 Benedict XVI, *Homily at the Easter Vigil* (22 March 2008).

26 Benedict XVI, *Homily at the Easter Vigil* (11 April 2009).

27 Benedict XVI, *Homily at the Easter Vigil* (7 April 2012).

28 Gregory of Tours is a great witness to many customs and traditions. See Peter Brown, *The Cult of the Saints: Its Rise and Function in Latin Christianity* (Chicago and London: The University of Chicago Press, 2015) 81.

29 Benedict XVI, *Homily at the Easter Vigil* (22 March 2008).

30 See *The Life of Adam and Eve* [Latin text], 40–43, in *The Old Testament Pseudepigrapha*, ed. and trans. James Charlesworth (New York: Doubleday, 1985) vol. 2, 274.

simply to an indefinite prolongation of this current life. It would have to transform our lives from within.”³¹

Certainly, Benedict does not leave things there: Easter has to do with our concrete lives. Bringing the mystery to a very personal dimension, he comments on the introit of the Easter Vigil:

“I arose and now I am still with you,” he says to each of us. My hand upholds you. Wherever you may fall, you will always fall into my hands. I am present even at the door of death. Where no one can accompany you further, and where you can bring nothing, even there I am waiting for you, and for you I will change darkness into light.³²

Easter, indeed, means a real change. But, how can a normal person of this postmodern world understand this mystery? Benedict dares to “borrow the language of the theory of evolution:” the resurrection of Christ

. . . is the greatest “mutation,” absolutely the most crucial leap into a totally new dimension that there has ever been in the long history of life and its development. . . . It is a qualitative leap in the history of ‘evolution’ and of life in general towards a new future life, towards a new world which, starting from Christ, already continuously permeates this world of ours, transforms it and draws it to itself.³³

This mystery becomes a reality for us in baptism, a theme very frequently present in these homilies.

In the homilies of these great thinkers we do not find dry and theoretical diversions of academics, but true oral theology, based on a real life of prayer and of deep knowledge, expressed in a way concerned with the good of the people. We do not find a trace of some of the common defects of today’s homilies: self-centeredness, simplistic and paternalistic tones, or even a condescending didac-

31 Benedict XVI, *Homily at the Easter Vigil* (3 April 2010).

32 Benedict XVI, *Homily at the Easter Vigil* (7 April 2007).

33 Benedict XVI, *Homily at the Easter Vigil* (15 April 2006).

ticism that ultimately excludes the presence of the mystery being celebrated. Rather, we find shepherds who elevate the minds and hearts of their people to what God offers in the liturgical celebrations, we encounter true and courageous explorations of the mysteries, significant developments in theological reflection, and concrete applications. We find how preaching is truly the place for practicing theology.

CONCLUSION

A simple and important goal for priestly formation should be to foster the awareness that priests *are* theologians, and that the ministry of preaching which will be exercised in some way throughout their lives will be the constant place to practice theology. Everything that was learned will eventually find an occasion for application; new situations will require us to think and to let God's revelation illumine the challenges and questions of today's Church.

Seeing the homily not as a burden, but as an occasion to make oral theology, will be a continuous stimulus for an on-going formation and will motivate the preparation of good homilies—which will edify the people of God and enrich the Church with new insights on God and the world. This is how theology became a reality; this is, for the most part, how it should fulfill its mission today.

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